DAILY READER

PARSHAT BERESHIT

Firstborns, changed things, and the breath of life

Monday, 5 October 2026 · Aliyah 2/7 (Genesis 2:4-2:19) · Daf Bekhorot 17

FROM THE LINKED SOURCES

When wine stops being wine

Jev score: 0.53 — Tested: whether the Rivash's kiddush ruling illuminates the daf's 'changed wine' ruling beyond the citation.

The daf's boldest move is analogical. Having ruled that wool of a 'changed' animal is disqualified — from sha'atnez, from the sky-blue of tzitzit, from contracting tzara'at — Rav Ashi extends the logic to wine: grapes from a vine trellised over a fig tree make wine unfit for libations. The verse 'an offering, and libations' (Leviticus 23:37) is read as a parity claim: just as an offering must be an un-changed animal, so libations must come from un-changed wine.

The Rivash applies exactly this logic centuries later to the kiddush cup: wine mixed with honey is unfit, the Geonim ruled, because it can no longer be poured as a libation on the altar. But the Ra'avad dissents, and the acharonim follow him: only wine disqualified by inferiority — uncovered, foul-smelling — loses its name; honeyed wine that still tastes of wine keeps it. The daf asks when a thing stops being itself; the Rivash answers on Friday night.

PARSHA · BERESHIT

Abel's firstlings

Jev score: 0.65 — Tested: how strongly the daf–parsha connection is grounded in the actual texts rather than a stretch.

Genesis 4:4 is the first animal offering in Scripture: 'And Abel — he too brought from the firstlings (מִבְּכֹרוֹת) of his flock, and from their fat.' The parsha's word is the daf's title word. Bekhorot 17 spends its day asking when an animal counts as a firstborn at all — does a ewe's goat-like kid qualify, do twins born 'at once' both count, who bears the burden of proof when the status is in doubt?

Before any law of bekhor is given, the Torah shows a human being choosing firstlings as his gift. The parsha never explains why Abel's offering was accepted and Cain's refused; the daf, in its way, takes up the question of fitness — what makes an offering acceptable, and what disqualifies it. A 0.65: grounded, not forced — the shared word is the shared subject.

Rejected by Jev: 'six days of Creation' derivation (0.03), 'be fruitful and multiply' (0.09), Cain/Abel acceptance criteria (0.47), animals 'according to their kind' (0.53), Adam names the animals (0.56).

NEWS CHECK

No genuine resonance this week

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr

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Jev score: 0.31 — Tested: whether the week's biggest stories resonate meaningfully with the daf's themes, strictly scored.

Tested against eight of the week's biggest stories — the stalled Gaza ceasefire, Iran's war rhetoric, the Bondi aftermath, the Taiwan arms deal, Ukraine's aid shortfall, the Venezuela blockade, Estonia's arson claim, the US funding showdown — nothing cleared the bar. The closest (0.31) was the ceasefire's indeterminate phase-2 status as a parallel to the daf's twin lambs of uncertain firstborn status.

But the ambiguity is shared and the substance different: the daf's doubt is ritual and evidentiary, the ceasefire's political. A shared mood of uncertainty is not a connection. So this section reports what it found: no genuine link this week — and says so plainly rather than forcing one.

All news candidates rejected by Jev (0.06–0.31): Gaza ceasefire (0.31), Ukraine frozen assets (0.25), US funding showdown (0.11), Iran war rhetoric (0.09), Venezuela blockade (0.08), Bondi aftermath (0.07), Estonia arson (0.07), Taiwan arms deal (0.06).

MAAGARIM · BEKHOR

בכור: Abel's gift becomes the sages' legal status

The Historical Dictionary sweep was blocked today — Cloudflare turned away both the server and the live browser session — so this section is built from the Sefaria texts on hand, and says so. The earliest sighting of בכור in the fetched texts is this week's own parsha: Abel brings מבכורות צאנו, 'from the firstlings of his flock' (Genesis 4:4) — a gift, freely chosen, before any law of firstborns exists.

By the daf, the word has hardened into a legal status: is this lamb a bekhor at all? The Gemara tests it by appearance — does the kid look like its mother? — by generation — exempt 'until ten generations' — by evidence — twin lambs born 'at once,' the burden of proof on the claimant. The arc: what began as Abel's spontaneous offering becomes a category the sages must adjudicate like surveyors — measuring, presuming, assigning. The word traveled from devotion to jurisprudence, and the daf is the courtroom.

Word data: מפעל המילון ההיסטורי של האקדמיה ללשון העברית *— the Historical Dictionary Project of the Academy of the Hebrew Language.*

Maagarim live sweep blocked 2026-10-05 (Cloudflare 403 on both the VM and the browser session); attestations above are from the fetched Sefaria texts only.

NLI ·

A study day for Bekhorot

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr

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In 1983 (27 Nisan 5743), the Beit Midrash Gavoha LeHalakha in Jerusalem's Geula neighborhood held a full day of study on the laws of bekhorot and orlah — the very subject of today's daf. The program, preserved in this flyer, included lectures on 'טהורה בזמן הזה בכור בהמה' (the firstborn animal nowadays), partnership with a non-Jew, and making tefillin straps from a firstborn's hide: the daf's world, taught as living law.


בית מדרש גבוה להלכה בהתיישבות החקלאית
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ביום לימוד בהלכות

בכורות וערלה

שיתקיים אי"ה ביום א' כ"ז ניסן תשמ"ג בישיבת דבר ירושלים רחוב חגי 24 גאולה, עיה"ק ירושלים תובב"א.

◆ סדר השיעורים ◆

אחה"צ 3.45 תפילת מנחה.

4.00 הרה"ג ר' קלמן כהנא שליט"א
ראש ביהמ"ד
בכור בהמה טהורה בזמן הזה.

4.45 הרב יהושע איתמר שליט"א
כולל נחלת יחיאל
חלק הגוי בשותפות.

5.30 הרב ישראל קופלוביץ שליט"א
חבר ביהמ"ד
עשיית סת"ם מעור בכור בהמה.

6.00 כיבוד קל

6.15 הרב יוסף אפרתי שליט"א
ראש המחלקה ההלכתית
מכון לחקר החקלאות עפ"י התורה
דרכי הקנין במכירת מבכירות.

7.00 הרה"ג ר' יצחק זילברשטין שליט"א
רב רמת אלחנן
ערלה ואיסורי הנאה.

בברכת התורה
הנהלת בית המדרש

Flyer for a day of study on the laws of bekhorot and orlah, Jerusalem, 27 Nisan 5743 (1983)

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr

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National Library of Israel (manifest license unverified — IIIF unreachable today)

יום לימוד בהלכות בכורות וערלה · 1983
https://www.nli.org.il/en/archives/NNL_ARCHIVE_AL997012947266705171

SHNAYIM MIKRA · ALIYAH 2

Genesis 2:4–2:19

The shnayim mikra practice — each verse twice in Hebrew, once in Targum Onkelos — is the week's daily portion. Today's aliyah is the Garden: heaven and earth told again from the ground up, man formed from dust, the breath of life, the garden planted eastward in Eden, the trees, the rivers, and the first command.

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr

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Genesis 2:4 · ×2

אֵ֚לֶּה תוֹלְדוֹת֙ הַשָּׁמַ֔יִם וְהָאָ֖רֶץ בְּהִבָּרְאָ֑ם בְּי֗וֹם עֲשׂ֛וֹת יְהוָ֥ה אֱלֹקִ֖ים אֶ֥רֶץ וְשָׁמָֽיִם׃

אֵ֚לֶּה תוֹלְדוֹת֙ הַשָּׁמַ֔יִם וְהָאָ֖רֶץ בְּהִבָּרְאָ֑ם בְּי֗וֹם עֲשׂ֛וֹת יְהוָ֥ה אֱלֹקִ֖ים אֶ֥רֶץ וְשָׁמָֽיִם׃

אִלֵּין תּוּלְדַת שְׁמַיָּא וְאַרְעָא כַּד אִתְבְּרִיאוּ בְּיוֹמָא דִּי עֲבַד יְיָ אֱלֹקִים אַרְעָא וּשְׁמַיָּא׃

אלקים

Maagarim · 18,278 attestations

A plural noun (plural of majesty) governing singular verbs — the whole theology in miniature. Maagarim's 775 pages run from Genesis 1 to Bialik and 1930s Baghdad.

Here it never stands alone: always יהוה אלקים. After chapter 3, the pairing vanishes from Tanakh.

יהוה

The Name · ~6,800× in Tanakh

The verb "to be" folded into a name — the God who shows up. Unpronounced since the Second Temple era; our printed vowels are borrowed from אדני.

Twenty times in Genesis 2–3 as יהוה אלקים, then never again. Only Eden gets the double name.

ארעא

CAL · Common Aramaic

ʾrʿ — ground, land, Earth; six senses from soil to "floor" (Palmyrene) to alchemical "residue" (Syriac). Cognate with Hebrew ארץ, via the צ/ע shift.

Onkelos flattens אדמה and ארץ into this one word — 6× in the aliyah. The Hebrew distinguishes; the Targum doesn't.

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr

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אדמה

אדום · דם · אדם — **the red family**

Ground, soil — kin to אדם (man), דם (blood), אדם (red). The aliyah's anthropology is a pun: man is red earth that bleeds.

Onkelos renders it ארעא, and the pun dies in Aramaic. Every translation is a commentary.

Genesis 2:5 · ×2

וְכֹל | שִׂיחַ הַשָּׂדֶה טֶרֶם יִהְיֶה בָּאָרֶץ וְכָל־עֵשֶׂב הַשָּׂדֶה טֶרֶם יִצְמָח כִּי֩
לֹא הִמְטִיר יְהוָ֨ה אֱלֹקִ֜ים עַל־הָאָ֗רֶץ וְאָדָ֥ם אַ֛יִן לַֽעֲבֹ֖ד אֶת־הָאֲדָמָֽה׃
וְכֹל | שִׂיחַ הַשָּׂדֶה טֶרֶם יִהְיֶה בָּאָרֶץ וְכָל־עֵשֶׂב הַשָּׂדֶה טֶרֶם יִצְמָח כִּי֩
לֹא הִמְטִיר יְהוָ֨ה אֱלֹקִ֜ים עַל־הָאָ֗רֶץ וְאָדָ֥ם אַ֛יִן לַֽעֲבֹ֖ד אֶת־הָאֲדָמָֽה׃
וְכֹל אִילָנֵי חַקְלָא עַד לָא הֲווּ בְאַרְעָא וְכָל עִסְבָּא דְחַקְלָא עַד לָא צְמַח אֲרֵי לָא
אַחִית מְטָרָא יְיָ אֱלֹקִים עַל אַרְעָא וֶאֱנָשׁ לֵית לְמִפְלַח יָת אַדְמְתָא׃

Genesis 2:6 · ×2

וְאֵד יַֽעֲלֶה מִן־הָאָ֔רֶץ וְהִשְׁקָ֖ה אֶת־כָּל־פְּנֵ֥י הָאֲדָמָֽה׃
וְאֵד יַֽעֲלֶה מִן־הָאָ֔רֶץ וְהִשְׁקָ֖ה אֶת־כָּל־פְּנֵ֥י הָאֲדָמָֽה׃
וַעֲנָנָא הֲוָה סָלֵיק מִן אַרְעָא וְאַשְׁקֵי יָת כָּל אַפֵּי אַדְמְתָא׃

Genesis 2:7 · ×2

וַיִּיצֶר֩ יְהוָ֨ה אֱלֹקִ֜ים אֶת־הָאָדָ֗ם עָפָר֙ מִן־הָֽאֲדָמָ֔ה וַיִּפַּ֖ח בְּאַפָּ֑יו נִשְׁמַ֥ת חַיִּ֖ים וַיְהִ֥י הָאָדָ֖ם לְנֶ֥פֶשׁ חַיָּֽה׃
וַיִּיצֶר֩ יְהוָ֨ה אֱלֹקִ֜ים אֶת־הָאָדָ֗ם עָפָר֙ מִן־הָֽאֲדָמָ֔ה וַיִּפַּ֖ח בְּאַפָּ֑יו נִשְׁמַ֥ת חַיִּ֖ים וַיְהִ֥י הָאָדָ֖ם לְנֶ֥פֶשׁ חַיָּֽה׃
וּבְרָא יְיָ אֱלֹקִים יָת אָדָם עַפְרָא מִן אַדְמְתָא וּנְפַח בְּאַפּוֹהִי נִשְׁמְתָא דְחַיֵּי וַהֲוַת בְּאָדָם לְרוּחַ מְמַלְלָא׃

Genesis 2:8 · ×2

וַיִּטַּ֥ע יְהוָ֨ה אֱלֹקִ֜ים גַּן־בְּעֵדֶ֗ן מִקֶּ֔דֶם וַיָּ֥שֶׂם שָׁ֖ם אֶת־הָאָדָ֥ם אֲשֶׁר־יָצָֽר׃
וַיִּטַּ֥ע יְהוָ֨ה אֱלֹקִ֜ים גַּן־בְּעֵדֶ֗ן מִקֶּ֔דֶם וַיָּ֥שֶׂם שָׁ֖ם אֶת־הָאָדָ֥ם אֲשֶׁר־יָצָֽר׃
וּנְצִיב יְיָ אֱלֹקִים גִּינְתָא בְעֵדֶן מִלְקַדְמִין וְאַשְׁוִי תַּמָּן יָת אָדָם דִּי בְרָא׃

Genesis 2:9 · ×2

וַיַּצְמַ֣ח יְהוָ֨ה אֱלֹקִ֜ים מִן־הָֽאֲדָמָ֗ה כָּל־עֵ֤ץ נֶחְמָד֙ לְמַרְאֶ֔ה וְטוֹב֙ לְמַאֲכָ֔ל וְעֵ֥ץ הַחַיִּ֖ים בְּתוֹךְ֙ הַגָּ֔ן וְעֵ֖ץ הַדַּ֥עַת טֽוֹב־וָרָֽע׃
וַיַּצְמַ֣ח יְהוָ֨ה אֱלֹקִ֜ים מִן־הָֽאֲדָמָ֗ה כָּל־עֵ֤ץ נֶחְמָד֙ לְמַרְאֶ֔ה וְטוֹב֙ לְמַאֲכָ֔ל וְעֵ֥ץ הַחַיִּ֖ים בְּתוֹךְ֙ הַגָּ֔ן וְעֵ֖ץ הַדַּ֥עַת טֽוֹב־וָרָֽע׃
וְאַצְמַח יְיָ אֱלֹקִים מִן אַרְעָא כָּל אִילָן דִּמְרַגֵּג לְמֶחֱזֵי וְטַב לְמֵיכַל וְאִילַן חַיָּא בְּמִצְיעוּת גִּינְתָא וְאִילַן דְּאָכְלִין פֵּירוֹהִי
חַכִּימִין בֵּין טַב לְבִישׁ׃

Genesis 2:10 · ×2

וְנָהָר֙ יֹצֵ֣א מֵעֵ֔דֶן לְהַשְׁקוֹת֙ אֶת־הַגָּ֔ן וּמִשָּׁ֖ם יִפָּרֵ֑ד וְהָיָ֖ה לְאַרְבָּעָ֥ה רָאשִֽׁים׃
וְנָהָר֙ יֹצֵ֣א מֵעֵ֔דֶן לְהַשְׁקוֹת֙ אֶת־הַגָּ֔ן וּמִשָּׁ֖ם יִפָּרֵ֑ד וְהָיָ֖ה לְאַרְבָּעָ֥ה רָאשִֽׁים׃
וְנַהֲרָא הֲוָה נָפִיק מֵעֵדֶן לְאַשְׁקָאָה יָת גִּינְתָא וּמִתַּמָּן יִתְפְּרֵשׁ וַהֲוֵי לְאַרְבְּעָה רֵישֵׁי נַהֲרִין׃

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr

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Genesis 2:11 · ×2

שֵׁם הָאֶחָד פִּישׁוֹן הוּא הַסֹּבֵב אֵת כָּל־אֶרֶץ הַחֲוִילָה אֲשֶׁר־שָׁם הַזָּהָב׃
שֵׁם הָאֶחָד פִּישׁוֹן הוּא הַסֹּבֵב אֵת כָּל־אֶרֶץ הַחֲוִילָה אֲשֶׁר־שָׁם הַזָּהָב׃
שׁוּם חַד פִּישׁוֹן הוּא מַקִּיף יָת כָּל אֲרַע דַּחֲוִילָה דִּי תַמָּן דַּהֲבָא׃

Genesis 2:12 · ×2

וּזְהַב הָאָרֶץ הַהִוא טוֹב שָׁם הַבְּדֹלַח וְאֶבֶן הַשֹּׁהַם׃
וּזְהַב הָאָרֶץ הַהִוא טוֹב שָׁם הַבְּדֹלַח וְאֶבֶן הַשֹּׁהַם׃
וְדַהֲבָא דְּאַרְעָא הַהִיא טָב תַּמָּן בְּדֹלְחָא וְאַבְנֵי בוּרְלָא׃

Genesis 2:13 · ×2

וְשֵׁם־הַנָּהָר הַשֵּׁנִי גִּיחוֹן הוּא הַסּוֹבֵב אֵת כָּל־אֶרֶץ כּוּשׁ׃
וְשֵׁם־הַנָּהָר הַשֵּׁנִי גִּיחוֹן הוּא הַסּוֹבֵב אֵת כָּל־אֶרֶץ כּוּשׁ׃
וְשׁוּם נַהֲרָא תִנְיָנָא גִּיחוֹן הוּא מַקִּיף יָת כָּל אַרְעָא דְּכוּשׁ׃

Genesis 2:14 · ×2

וְשֵׁם הַנָּהָר הַשְּׁלִישִׁי חִדֶּקֶל הוּא הָהֹלֵךְ קִדְמַת אַשּׁוּר וְהַנָּהָר הָרְבִיעִי הוּא פְּרָת׃
וְשֵׁם הַנָּהָר הַשְּׁלִישִׁי חִדֶּקֶל הוּא הָהֹלֵךְ קִדְמַת אַשּׁוּר וְהַנָּהָר הָרְבִיעִי הוּא פְּרָת׃
וְשׁוּם נַהֲרָא תְּלִיתָאָה דִּיגְלַת הוּא מְהַלֵּךְ לְמַדִּינְחָא דְּאַתּוּר וְנַהֲרָא רְבִיעָאָה הוּא פְּרָת׃

Genesis 2:15 · ×2

וַיִּקַּח יְהוָה אֱלֹקִים אֶת־הָאָדָם וַיַּנִּחֵהוּ בְגַן־עֵדֶן לְעָבְדָהּ וּלְשָׁמְרָהּ׃
וַיִּקַּח יְהוָה אֱלֹקִים אֶת־הָאָדָם וַיַּנִּחֵהוּ בְגַן־עֵדֶן לְעָבְדָהּ וּלְשָׁמְרָהּ׃
וּדְבַר יְיָ אֱלֹקִים יָת אָדָם וְאַשְׁרֵיהּ בְּגִינְתָא דְעֵדֶן לְמִפְלְחַהּ וּלְמִטְרַהּ׃

Genesis 2:16 · ×2

וַיְצַו יְהוָה אֱלֹקִים עַל־הָאָדָם לֵאמֹר מִכֹּל עֵץ־הַגָּן אָכֹל תֹּאכֵל׃
וַיְצַו יְהוָה אֱלֹקִים עַל־הָאָדָם לֵאמֹר מִכֹּל עֵץ־הַגָּן אָכֹל תֹּאכֵל׃
וּפַקֵּיד יְיָ אֱלֹקִים עַל אָדָם לְמֵימָר מִכֹּל אִילַן גִּינְתָא מֵיכַל תֵּיכוּל׃

Genesis 2:17 · ×2

וּמֵעֵץ הַדַּעַת טוֹב וָרָע לֹא תֹאכַל מִמֶּנּוּ כִּי בְיוֹם אֲכָלְךָ מִמֶּנּוּ מוֹת תָּמוּת׃
וּמֵעֵץ הַדַּעַת טוֹב וָרָע לֹא תֹאכַל מִמֶּנּוּ כִּי בְיוֹם אֲכָלְךָ מִמֶּנּוּ מוֹת תָּמוּת׃
וּמֵאִילָן דְּאָכְלִין פֵּירוֹהִי חַכִּימִין בֵּין טַב לְבִישׁ לָא תֵיכוּל מִנֵּהּ אֲרֵי בְּיוֹמָא דְתֵיכוּל מִנֵּהּ מֵימַת תְּמוּת׃

Genesis 2:18 · ×2

וַיֹּאמֶר יְהוָה אֱלֹקִים לֹא־טוֹב הֱיוֹת הָאָדָם לְבַדּוֹ אֶעֱשֶׂה־לּוֹ עֵזֶר כְּנֶגְדּוֹ׃
וַיֹּאמֶר יְהוָה אֱלֹקִים לֹא־טוֹב הֱיוֹת הָאָדָם לְבַדּוֹ אֶעֱשֶׂה־לּוֹ עֵזֶר כְּנֶגְדּוֹ׃
וַאֲמַר יְיָ אֱלֹקִים לָא תַקִּין לְמֶהֱוֵי אָדָם בִּלְחוֹדוֹהִי אֶעְבֵּד לֵהּ סְמַךְ לְקִבְלֵהּ׃

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr

DAILY READER

PARSHAT BERESHIT

Firstborns, changed things, and the breath of life

Monday, 5 October 2026 · Aliyah 2/7 (Genesis 2:4-2:19) · Daf Bekhorot 17

Genesis 2:19 · ×2

וַיִּצֶר֩ יְהוָ֨ה אֱלֹקִ֜ים מִן־הָאֲדָמָ֗ה כָּל־חַיַּ֤ת הַשָּׂדֶה֙ וְאֵת֙ כָּל־עוֹף֣ הַשָּׁמַ֔יִם וַיָּבֵ֖א אֶל־הָאָדָ֑ם לִרְאוֹת֙
מַה־יִּקְרָא־ל֔וֹ וְכֹ֗ל אֲשֶׁ֤ר יִקְרָא־לוֹ֙ הָאָדָ֔ם נֶ֥פֶשׁ חַיָּ֖ה הִ֥וא שְׁמֽוֹ׃
וַיִּצֶר֩ יְהוָ֨ה אֱלֹקִ֜ים מִן־הָאֲדָמָ֗ה כָּל־חַיַּ֤ת הַשָּׂדֶה֙ וְאֵת֙ כָּל־עוֹף֣ הַשָּׁמַ֔יִם וַיָּבֵ֖א אֶל־הָאָדָ֑ם לִרְאוֹת֙
מַה־יִּקְרָא־ל֔וֹ וְכֹ֗ל אֲשֶׁ֤ר יִקְרָא־לוֹ֙ הָאָדָ֔ם נֶ֥פֶשׁ חַיָּ֖ה הִ֥וא שְׁמֽוֹ׃
וּבְרָא יְיָ אֱלֹקִים מִן אַרְעָא כָּל חֵוַת בָּרָא וְיָת כָּל עוֹפָא דִּשְׁמַיָּא וְאַיְתֵהּ לְוָת אָדָם לְמֶחֱזֵי מַה יִקְרֵי לֵהּ וְכֹל דִּי הֲוָה קָרֵי
לֵהּ אָדָם נַפְשָׁא חַיְתָא הוּא שְׁמֵהּ׃

GEMS ·

Three things to notice in this aliyah

1 · THE DOUBLE NAME THAT APPEARS NOWHERE ELSE. Count them: יהוה אלקים, יהוה אלקים, twenty times across Genesis 2–3 — and then never again in all of Tanakh. The rest of Scripture picks one name or the other. Only the Garden gets the compound, the God of covenant (יהוה) fused to the God of creation (אלקים), as if the text wants you to know that the hands that planted Eden are the same hands that will walk in it "לרוח היום." When Adam and Eve leave, the double name leaves with them.

2 · FOUR RIVERS, NO MAP. "ונהר יצא מעדן להשקות את־הגן" — a river leaves Eden and splits into four heads: פישון, גיחון, חדקל, פרת (2:10–14). The Pishon "encircles Havilah, where there is gold"; the Gihon "encircles Cush"; the Hiddekel "flows east of Assyria"; the Perat needs no introduction. Two thousand years of commentators have placed these rivers with total confidence on maps that contradict each other. The text gives you landmarks from a world that no longer exists — Eden's geography is drawn so precisely, and so impossibly, that you can't help trying to find it anyway.

3 · THE RED FAMILY. אדמה (ground), אדם (man), דם (blood), אדם (red) — one root-cluster, one color. The aliyah builds its anthropology out of the pun: man is red earth that bleeds. Onkelos, translating into Aramaic, renders אדמה as ארעא — a fine translation that murders the pun, because in Aramaic ארעא sounds nothing like אדם. Every translation is a commentary, and sometimes the commentary is what gets lost.

929 · II SAMUEL 24 (CH. 287)

The census, the plague, the threshing floor

The book of Samuel ends here — and it ends with its strangest chapter. David orders a census; God is angry; 70,000 die; and the plague stops at a Jebusite's threshing floor, on the exact spot where the Temple will stand. Twenty-five verses, five acts: the census (1–9), David's remorse (10), Gad's three punishments (11–14), the plague (15–17), the altar (18–25).

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr

DAILY READER

PARSHAT BERESHIT

Firstborns, changed things, and the breath of life

Monday, 5 October 2026 · Aliyah 2/7 (Genesis 2:4-2:19) · Daf Bekhorot 17

THE CRUX — 24:1, "who incited David?" Rashi, in rare candor: on "God's anger was again kindled against Israel" — "I do not know what it was [they did]." The text withholds the sin. Radak fills the gap: hidden sins, punished through a "cause" — God put the census into David's heart. Ralbag: the sin was David's own — the anointed king "placed his trust in the flesh of his forearm," in having many people, instead of in God alone. Malbim fires six questions at the verse: why ויסת (incite, a hostile verb)? Why does David say ספר/מנה when the Torah always says פקד for censuses? Moses and Saul counted Israel — why was this census a sin?

MALBIM'S ANSWER — the verb is the sin. The Torah's census verb is פקד — appoint, attend, take notice. David says ספר/מנה — bare numbering, people as inventory, with no half-shekel kofer (Ex. 30:12). The sin isn't counting; it's how you count. Joab sees it before David does: "May the LORD your God increase the people a hundredfold… why does my lord want this?" (24:3) — the hitman becomes the conscience, and the king overrules him.

DAVID'S CHOICE — 24:14. Gad offers three punishments: seven years of famine, three months of flight, three days of plague — a descending triad. David: "Let us fall into the hand of God, for His mercies are great." Rashi (Midrash Tehillim): David reasoned — famine sends men into human hands (they flee to Egypt for bread); the sword brings disgrace before the nations and lets Israel say he hides behind his warriors. Pestilence is the one everyone is equal before — "the least of them is very difficult." Radak: only דבר has no human intermediary; it is "the hand of God only."

THE GEM — Radak on 24:16. God projected the angel next to Araunah's threshing floor deliberately — so David would see it there, pray there, and the plague's stopping would mark the place of entreaty: "there will be the Holy Temple, the house of prayer." The census sin — trusting in numbers — ends at the place where Israel learns to trust in the House. The book of Samuel closes with its eyes on the Temple. And the price: 50 silver shekels here, 600 gold in I Chronicles 21:25 — Rashi and Malbim (Zevachim 116b): 50 from each tribe, or 50 for the threshing floor now and 600 for the whole field once fire fell from heaven (Chronicles adds what Samuel omits: "the verses fill in, in one place, what is missing in another").

THE PARALLEL — I Chronicles 21 tells the same story with one shattering difference: where Samuel says God incited David ("ויסת את דוד"), Chronicles says שטן stood against Israel and incited him. Metzudat David: שטן here is the yetzer hara, the evil inclination — not a cosmic devil. Ralbag: "the matter is one" — Samuel attributes it to divine anger, Chronicles externalizes it. Same event, two framings; the ambiguity in Samuel is the point, and Chronicles is its commentary.

LITERARY DEVICES TO CARRY: (1) The agency blur of 24:1 — the grammar makes God the inciter and never resolves it. (2) The shepherd inversion of 24:17 — "I am the one who sinned… but these sheep, what have they done? Let Your hand be against me" — David

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr

PARSHAT BERESHIT

Firstborns, changed things, and the breath of life

Monday, 5 October 2026 · Aliyah 2/7 (Genesis 2:4-2:19) · Daf Bekhorot 17

reclaims the shepherd-king image as the flock suffers for the shepherd. (3) The census route (24:5–8) — Aroer to Gilead to Dan to Tyre, nine months and twenty days; the list's exhaustiveness performs the sin. Counting is possessing; possessing is trusting.

MISHNAH YOMI · OHOLOT 8:3–4

What transmits impurity, what blocks it

Oholot 8:3

אֵלּוּ מְבִיאִין וְלֹא חוֹצְצִין: הַשִּׁדָּה, וְהַתֵּבָה, וְהַמִּגְדָּל, כַּוֶּרֶת הַקַּשׁ, כַּוֶּרֶת הַקָּנִים, וּבוֹר סְפִינָה אֲלֶכְסַנְדְּרִית, שֶׁאֵין לָהֶם שׁוּלַיִם וְאֵינָן מַחֲזִיקִים אַרְבָּעִים סְאָה בַּלַּח שֶׁהֵם כּוֹרַיִם בַּיָּבֵשׁ, וִירִיעָה, וּסְקוֹרְטִיָא, וְקַטָבּוֹלְיָא, וְסָדִין, וּמַפָּץ, וּמַחֲצֶלֶת, שֶׁאֵין עֲשׂוּיִין אֹהָלִים, וּבְהֵמָה וְחַיָּה שֶׁמֵּתוּ, וְאֹכָלִים טְמֵאִים. מוֹסֶף עֲלֵיהֶם הָרֵחַיִם שֶׁל אָדָם:

The following bring impurity but do not block it: a chest, a box, a cupboard, a straw beehive, a reed beehive, an Alexandrian ship's water tank — where these have no proper bottoms and hold less than forty se'ah liquid (two kor dry). A curtain, a leather apron, a leather undercover, a sheet, a mat, a mattress — when not made tent-wise. Cattle or wild animals that died, and impure-susceptible foods. Added to these: a human-powered mill.

Rambam: "שאין להם שולים" doesn't mean level edges — it means lopsided, one side jutting past the other (cf. Kelim 15). Fabrics spread flat — over a window, between houses — do not block; only tent-shaped spreads block (cf. 15:5). The governing principle: דבר טמא אינו חוצץ — an impure thing cannot block. Dead animals and susceptible foods transmit impurity but block nothing, since in an opening they would themselves contract corpse-impurity. The hand-mill joins this list: over a skylight it blocks nothing unless fixed in place — a blocker must be something one does not intend to move (ch. 6).

Oholot 8:4

אֵלּוּ חוֹצְצִים וְלֹא מְבִיאִין: מַסֶּכֶת פְּרוּסָה, וַחֲבִילֵי הַמִּטָּה, וְהַמַּשְׁפָּלוֹת, וְהַסְּרִיגוֹת שֶׁבַּחֲלוֹנוֹת:

The following block impurity but do not bring it: a loom with the woof spread out, bed-ropes, waste baskets, and window lattices.

Rambam: מסכת פרוסה is a mat spread flat; חבילי המטה are ropes woven beam-to-beam; משפלות is the dung-carrier's basket, a rope lattice; window lattices (Targum renders שבכה as סריגה) block only if no single hole reaches a full handbreadth square.

ON THE JUDEO-ARABIC ORIGINAL: Rambam wrote his Mishnah commentary in Judeo-Arabic (Arabic in Hebrew script). Sefaria hosts only the medieval Hebrew translation — the Arabic isn't digitized there. The translation is famously literal, so the Arabic shines through the Hebrew. Three markers to learn — once you know these, you can navigate any page of the original:

יעני (yaʿnī, "it means") — surfaces in the Hebrew as ל"ר ("רוצה לומר"). Rambam uses it to gloss his own terms, twice in 8:3. Wherever you see ל"ר, you're hearing yaʿnī.

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr

DAILY READER

PARSHAT BERESHIT

Firstborns, changed things, and the breath of life

Monday, 5 October 2026 · Aliyah 2/7 (Genesis 2:4-2:19) · Daf Bekhorot 17

ליס אלאמר (laysa al-amr, "the point is not that...") — surfaces as "אין ענינן ש..." / "אין הענין ש...". Rambam's Hebrew ענין here is doing the work of Arabic אמר (amr, "matter"). A classic translationese tell.

ואעלם (wa-ʿlam, "and know!") — surfaces as "ודע" / "ודע זה", with its twin כמא בינא (kamā bayyannā, "as we have explained") surfacing as "כמו שביארנו". Rambam signposts every argument with these two. Learn them and the original opens up.

The full Arabic is printed in the Qafih edition (פירוש המשניות לרמב"ם, מוסד הרב קוק), Arabic facing Hebrew — that's the source to work from when you're ready.

RASHI

Rashi on the day's aliyah

All 24 of Rashi's comments on the aliyah, printed in full. The densest cluster falls on Genesis 2:7 — four comments on the forming of man, each one built from midrash: the double yod of ויצר, the dust gathered from the four corners, the breath from above and below, the living soul that speaks.

אלה.
הָאֲמוּרִים לְמַעְלָה:

אלה *THESE [ARE THE GENERATIONS] — "These" means those that are mentioned above.*

תולדות השמים והארץ בהבראם ביום עשות ה'.
לְמֶדֶךְ שֶׁכֻּלָּם נִבְרְאוּ בָרִאשׁוֹן. דָּבָר אַחֵר בְּהִבָּרְאָם, בְּה' בָּרָאָם, שֶׁנֶּ' בְיָהּ ה' צוּר עוֹלָמִים (ישעיהו כ"ו),

בְּב' אוֹתִיּוֹת הַלָּלוּ שֶׁל הַשֵּׁם יָצַר שְׁנֵי עוֹלָמִים,

תולדות השמים והארץ בהבראם ביום עשות ה' *THESE ARE THE PRODUCTIONS OF THE HEAVEN AND OF THE EARTH WHEN THEY WERE CREATED, IN THE DAY THE LORD GOD MADE EARTH AND HEAVEN — The verse teaches you that all of them (the productions of heaven and earth) were created on the first day when God made earth and heaven.*

וְלְמֶדֶךְ כָּאן שֶׁהָעוֹלָם הַזֶּה נִבְרָא בְּהֵ"א,

Another explanation of the word בהבראם:

רֶמֶז שֶׁיֵּרְדוּ לְמַטָּה לִרְאוֹת שַׁחַת כְּהֵ"א זֹאת שֶׁסְּתוּמָה מִכָּל צְדָדִים וּפְתוּחָה לְמַטָּה לֶרֶדֶת דֶּרֶךְ שָׁם:

It may be divided as בראם בה' *He created them with the letter* ה', *as it is said, (Isaiah 26:4)* כי ביה ה' צור עולמים *"For in Jah, the Lord, is the rock of worlds", which may be explained to mean (taking* צור *in sense of Former, Creator) "for by means of* ב *these two letters* ה י *of the Divine Name (*יהוה*) God formed the two worlds" (Menachot 29b), and this verse teaches that this world was created by means of the* ה' *— a suggestion that all created beings must descend to the nether world "to behold the pit" — the world being like this letter* ה' *, which is closed on all sides but open at the bottom, thus giving a way by which they must descend.*

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DAILY READER

PARSHAT BERESHIT

Firstborns, changed things, and the breath of life

Monday, 5 October 2026 · Aliyah 2/7 (Genesis 2:4-2:19) · Daf Bekhorot 17

טרם יהיה בארץ.

כָּל טֶרֶם שֶׁבַּמִּקְרָא לְשׁוֹן עַד לֹא הוּא, וְאֵינוֹ לְשׁוֹן קֹדֶם, וְאֵינוֹ נִפְעָל לוֹמַר הִטְרִים, כַּאֲשֶׁר יֹאמַר הַקְדִּים וְזֶה מוֹכִיחַ,

וְעוֹד אַחֵר כִּי טֶרֶם תִּירָאוּן (שמות ט) עֲדַיִן לֹא תִירָאוּן,

טרם יהיה בארץ *WAS NOT YET IN THE EARTH — Wherever* טרם *occurs in the Scriptures it means "not yet" and does not mean "before".*

וְאַף זֶה תִּפָּרֵשׁ עֲדַיִן לֹא הָיָה בָּאָרֶץ,

It cannot be made into a verbal form, saying הטרים *as one says* הקדים *(verbal form of* קדם*) and this passage proves that this is the meaning and not "before" as well as another (Exodus 9:30),* טרם תראון כי *"that ye do not yet fear the Lord".*

כְּשֶׁנִּגְמְרָה בְּרִיאַת הָעוֹלָם בַּשִּׁשִּׁי קֹדֶם שֶׁנִּבְרָא אָדָם, וְכָל עֵשֶׂב הַשָּׂדֶה טֶרֶם יִצְמַח, עֲדַיִן לֹא צָמַח, וּבְג' שֶׁכָּתוּב תּוֹצֵא הָאָרֶץ, לֹא יָצְאוּ,

Therefore you must explain this verse also thus: "No plant of the field was yet in the earth" at the time when the creation of the world was completed on the sixth day before man was created, and וכל עשב השדה טרם יצמח *means "and every herb of the field had not yet grown".*

אֶלָּא עַל פֶּתַח קַרְקַע עָמְדוּ עַד יוֹם שִׁשִּׁי:

But as regards the third day of creation about which it is written "The earth brought forth etc." this does not signify that they came forth above the ground but that they remained at the opening of the ground (i. e. just below the surface) until the sixth day (Chullin 60a).

כי לא המטיר.

וּמַ"ט לֹא הִמְטִיר? לְפִי שֶׁאָדָם אַיִן לַעֲבֹד אֶת הָאֲדָמָה, וְאֵין מַכִּיר בְּטוֹבָתָם שֶׁל גְּשָׁמִים,

וּכְשֶׁבָּא אָדָם וְיָדַע שֶׁהֵם צֹרֶךְ לָעוֹלָם,

כי לא המטיר *BECAUSE GOD HAD NOT CAUSED IT TO RAIN — And what is the reason that God had not caused it to rain?* כי אדם אין לעבוד את האדמה *BECAUSE THERE WAS NO MAN TO TILL THE GROUND, and there was, therefore, no one to recognize the utility of rain.*

הִתְפַּלֵּל עֲלֵיהֶם וְיָרְדוּ וְצָמְחוּ הָאִילָנוֹת וְהַדְּשָׁאִים:

When Adam came (was created), however, and he realised that it was necessary for the world, he prayed for it and it fell, so that trees and verdure sprang forth.

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr

DAILY READER

PARSHAT BERESHIT

Firstborns, changed things, and the breath of life

Monday, 5 October 2026 · Aliyah 2/7 (Genesis 2:4-2:19) · Daf Bekhorot 17

ה' אלקים.

ה' הוּא שְׁמוֹ, אֱלֹקִים שֶׁהוּא שַׁלִּיט וְשׁוֹפֵט עַל כֹּל,

ה׳ אלקים *THE LORD GOD — The Lord (יהוה) is His Name, whereas* אלקים *signifies that He is Ruler and Judge over all.*

וְכֵן פֵּרוּשׁ זֶה בְּכָל מָקוֹם לְפִי פְּשׁוּטוֹ, ה' שֶׁהוּא אֱלֹקִים:

This, too, is its meaning, according to the plain sense, wherever it occurs:

The Lord who is God (Ruler and Judge).

ואד יעלה.

לְעִנְיַן בְּרִיאָתוֹ שֶׁל אָדָם, הֶעֱלָה הַתְּהוֹם וְהִשְׁקָה עֲנָנִים לִשְׁרוֹת הֶעָפָר וְנִבְרָא אָדָם, כְּגַבָּל זֶה,

ואד יעלה *AND A MIST WENT UP — This has reference to the creation of Adam:*

viz., He caused the deep to rise and filled the clouds with water to moisten the dust, and man was created.

שֶׁנּוֹתֵן מַיִם וְאַחַ"כ לָשׁ אֶת הָעִסָּה, אַף כָּאן, וְהִשְׁקָה, וְאַחַ"כ וַיִּיצֶר:

It is like a kneader of bread who first pours in water and afterwards kneads the dough — similarly here:

He first watered the ground and afterwards He formed man (Genesis Rabbah 14:1).

וייצר.

שְׁתֵּי יְצִירוֹת, יְצִירָה לָעוֹלָם הַזֶּה וְיִצִירָה לִתְחִיַּת הַמֵּתִים,

וייצר *AND GOD FORMED — Here the letter yod is written twice to intimate that there were two formations — a formation of man for this world, and a formation of man for resurrection;*

אֲבָל בַּבְּהֵמָה שֶׁאֵינָהּ עוֹמֶדֶת לַדִּין לֹא נִכְתַּב בִּיצִירָתָהּ שְׁנֵי יוּדִי"ן:

in the case of animals, however, which will not stand after death for judgment before God the word referring to their formation— ויצר *—(Genesis 2:19) is not written with two yods (Midrash Tanchuma, Tazria 1).*

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr

PARSHAT BERESHIT

Firstborns, changed things, and the breath of life

Monday, 5 October 2026 · Aliyah 2/7 (Genesis 2:4-2:19) · Daf Bekhorot 17

עפר מן האדמה.

צָבַר עֲפָרוֹ מִכָּל הָאֲדָמָה מֵאַרְבַּע רוּחוֹת,

שֶׁכָּל מָקוֹם שֶׁיָּמוּת שָׁם תְּהֵא קוֹלַטְתּוֹ לִקְבוּרָה.

עפר מן האדמה *DUST OF THE EARTH — He gathered his dust (i. e. that from which he was made) from the entire earth — from its four corners — in order that wherever he might die, it should receive him for burial (Midrash Tanchuma, Pekudei 3).*

דְּ"אַ נָטַל עֲפָרוֹ מִמָּקוֹם שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר בּוֹ מִזְבַּח אֲדָמָה תַּעֲשֶׂה לִּי (שמות כ'),

Another explanation:

הַלְוַאי תְּהֶיֶה לוֹ כַּפָּרָה וְיוּכַל לַעֲמֹד:

He took his dust from that spot on which the Holy Temple with the altar of atonement was in later times to be built of which it is said, (Exodus 20:24) “An altar of earth thou shalt make for Me” saying, “Would that this sacred earth may be an expiation for him so that he may be able to endure” (Genesis Rabbah 14:8).

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr

DAILY READER

PARSHAT BERESHIT

Firstborns, changed things, and the breath of life

Monday, 5 October 2026 · Aliyah 2/7 (Genesis 2:4-2:19) · Daf Bekhorot 17

ויפח באפיו.

עֲשָׂאוֹ מִן הַתַּחְתּוֹנִים וּמִן הָעֶלְיוֹנִים,

גּוּפוֹ מִן הַתַּחְתּוֹנִים וּנְשָׁמָה מִן הָעֶלְיוֹנִים,

ויפח באפיו *AND BREATHED INTO HIS NOSTRILS — He made him of both, of earthly and of heavenly matter:*

לְפִי שֶׁבְּיוֹם רִאשׁוֹן נִבְרְאוּ שָׁמַיִם וָאָרֶץ, בַּשֵּׁנִי בָּרָא רָקִיעַ לָעֶלְיוֹנִים,

בַּשְּׁלִישִׁי תֵּרָאֶה הַיַּבָּשָׁה לַתַּחְתּוֹנִים, בָּרְבִיעִי בָּרָא מְאוֹרוֹת לָעֶלְיוֹנִים,

the body of the earthly, and the soul of the heavenly.

בַּחֲמִישִׁי יִשְׁרְצוּ הַמַּיִם לַתַּחְתּוֹנִים,

הֵזַקַק בַּשִּׁשִּׁי לִבְרֹאוֹת בּוֹ בָּעֶלְיוֹנִים וּבַתַּחְתּוֹנִים,

For on the first day were created heaven and earth, on the second, He created the firmament for the heavenly beings, on the third He said, "Let the dry land appear" — for the earthly beings, on the fourth He created the lights for the heavenly beings, on the fifth He said, "Let the waters swarm..." — for the earthly beings.

וְאִם לָאו יֵשׁ קִנְאָה בְּמַעֲשֵׂה בְרֵאשִׁית,

שֶׁיִּהְיוּ אֵלּוּ רַבִּים עַל אֵלּוּ בְּבְרִיאַת יוֹם אֶחָד:

Consequently on the sixth there had to be created a being composed of both, of heavenly and of earthly matter, for otherwise there would have been envy (lack of harmony) among the works of Creation, in that there would have been devoted to one class of them one day more of the Creation than to the others (Genesis Rabbah 12:8).

לנפש חיה.

אַף בְּהֵמָה וְחַיָּה נִקְרְאוּ נֶפֶשׁ חַיָּה, אַךְ זוֹ שֶׁל אָדָם חַיָּה שֶׁבְּכֻלָּן, שֶׁנִּתּוֹסֵף בּוֹ דֵּעָה וְדִבּוּר:

לנפש חיה *A LIVING SOUL — Also cattle and beasts are called* נפש חיה *(1:20, 22, 24), but the* נפש *of man is the most highly developed of all of them, because to him was granted understanding and speech.*

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr

DAILY READER

PARSHAT BERESHIT

Firstborns, changed things, and the breath of life

Monday, 5 October 2026 · Aliyah 2/7 (Genesis 2:4-2:19) · Daf Bekhorot 17

מקדם.

בְּמִזְרָחוֹ שֶׁל עֵדֶן נָטַע אֶת הַגָּן. וְאִם תֹּאמַר,

הֲרֵי כְּבָר כָּתַב וַיִּבְרָא אֶת הָאָדָם וְגוֹ',

מקדם *EASTWARD — In the east of Eden He planted the garden.*

רְאֵיתִי בְּבְרַיְתָא שֶׁל ר"א בְּנוֹ שֶׁל רַ' יוֹסֵי הַגְּלִילִי מל"ב מִדּוֹת שֶׁהַתּוֹרָה נִדְרֶשֶׁת, וְזוֹ אַחַת מֵהֶן,

Should you say, however, it is already written, (1:27) "and He created the man etc.", then I say that I have seen the Baraitha of R. Eliezer the son of R. José the Galilean, dealing with the thirty two rules of interpretation according to which the Torah (Agada) can be interpreted, and the following is one of them:

כְּלָל שֶׁלְּאַחֲרָיו מַעֲשֶׂה הוּא פְּרָטוֹ שֶׁל רִאשׁוֹן, וַיִּבְרָא אֶת הָאָדָם זֶהוּ כְּלָל,

when a general statement of an action is followed by a detailed account of it, the latter is a particularisation of the former: — "And He created the man" is a general statement, but it does not explicitly state whence he was created and what God did unto him.

סָתַם בְּרִיאָתוֹ מֵהֵיכָן וְסָתַם מַעֲשָׂיו, חָזַר וּפֵרֵשׁ וַיִּיצֶר ה' אֱלֹקִים וְגוֹ',

וַיַּצְמַח לוֹ גַּן עֵדֶן וַיַּנִּיחֵהוּ בְּגַן עֵדֶן וַיַּפֵּל עָלָיו תַּרְדֵּמָה, הַשּׁוֹמֵעַ סְבוּר שֶׁהוּא מַעֲשֶׂה אַחֵר, וְאֵינוֹ אֶלָּא פְּרָטוֹ שֶׁל רִאשׁוֹן;

Now it repeats it and explains these things: "And the Lord God formed man", "and He made to grow for him the garden of Eden", and He caused a deep sleep to fall upon him." He who hears this might think that it is a different account entirely, whereas it is nothing else but the details of the former general statement.

וְכֵן אֵצֶל הַבְּהֵמָה חָזַר וְכָתַב וַיִּצֶר ה' וגו' מִן הָאֲדָמָה כָּל חַיַּת הַשָּׂדֶה,

Similarly with reference to the cattle the creation of which has been mentioned above (1:27).

כְּדֵי לְפָרֵשׁ וַיָּבֵא אֶל הָאָדָם לִקְרוֹת שֵׁם וּלְלַמֵּד עַל הָעוֹפוֹת שֶׁנִּבְרְאוּ מִן הָרְקִיק:

it resumes and writes, (2:19) "and out of the ground the Lord [God] formed every beast of the field etc.", for the purpose of explaining "and He brought them unto the man to give them names", and also to state that the fowls were created from the swamps.

ויצמח.

לְעִנְיַן הַגַּן הַכָּתוּב מְדַבֵּר:

ויצמח *AND HE CAUSED TO GROW — The verse speaks here only with reference to the garden (Genesis Rabbah 13:1)*

בתוך הגן.

בָּאֶמְצַע:

בתוך הגן *IN THE MIDST OF THE GARDEN — means in the very centre of the garden.*

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DAILY READER

PARSHAT BERESHIT

Firstborns, changed things, and the breath of life

Monday, 5 October 2026 · Aliyah 2/7 (Genesis 2:4-2:19) · Daf Bekhorot 17

פישון.

הוּא נִילוּס נָהָר מִצְרַיִם, וְעַל שֵׁם שֶׁמֵּימָיו מִתְבָּרְכִין וְעוֹלִין וּמַשְׁקִין אֶת הָאָרֶץ נִקְרָא פִּישׁוֹן כְּמוֹ וּפָשׁוּ פָּרָשָׁיו (חבקוק א') דְּ"אַ פִּישׁוֹן, שֶׁהוּא מְגַדֵּל פִּשְׁתָּן,

פישון *PISHON — This is the Nile, the River of Egypt.*

Because its waters grow plentiful and rise and water the land, it is called Pishon, the name being of the same root as the verb in (Habakkuk 1:8) ופשו פרשיו *"and their horsemen increased";*

שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר עַל מִצְרַיִם (ישעיהו י"ט) וּבֹשׁוּ עֹבְדֵי פִּשְׁתִּים:

another interpretation of the name Pishon is:

*it is so called because it grows flax (*פשתן*) (Genesis Rabbah 16:2) for it is said with reference to Egypt (Isaiah 19:9) "Moreover they that work in combed flax, shall be ashamed."*

גיחון.

שֶׁהַיָּה הוֹלֵךְ וְהוֹמֶה, וְהֶמְיָתוֹ גְּדוֹלָה מְאֹד, כְּמוֹ כִּי יִגַּח (שמות כ"א), שֶׁמְּנֻגָּח וְהוֹלֵךְ וְהוֹמֶה:

גיחון *GICHON — It is so called because it flows on with a roar, its roaring being very noisy,—similar in meaning to (Exodus 21:28)* וכי יגח *"And if an [ox] gore" — for when it gores it rushes on roaring (Berakhot 59b.).*

חדקל.

שֶׁמֵּימָיו חַדִּין וְקַלִּין:

חדקל *TIGRIS — It is called* חדקל *because its waters are pungent in taste (*חד*) and light in weight (*קל*) (Berakhot 59b).*

פרת.

שֶׁמֵּימָיו פָּרִין וְרָבִין וּמַבְרִין אֶת הָאָדָם: כוש ואשור. עֲדַיִן לֹא הָיוּ, וְכָתַב הַמִּקְרָא עַל שֵׁם הֶעָתִיד:

פרת *EUPHRATES — It is called* פרת *because its waters grow (*פרה*) and increase and make men healthy (Berakhot 59b).* כוש ואשור *CUSH AND ASHUR did not then exist as countries, but Scripture writes with reference to the names which those districts would bear in the future (Ketubot 10b;*

Genesis Rabbah 16).

קדמת אשור.

לְמִזְרָחָהּ שֶׁל אַשּׁוּר:

קדמת אשור *means AT THE EAST OF ASHUR.*

הוא פרת.

הֶחָשׁוּב עַל כֻּלָּם, הַנִּזְכָּר עַל שֵׁם א"י:

הוא פרת *IS THE EUPHRATES — the most important of all, being mentioned in connection with the Land of Israel (Genesis Rabbah 16:3).*

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr

DAILY READER

PARSHAT BERESHIT

Firstborns, changed things, and the breath of life

Monday, 5 October 2026 · Aliyah 2/7 (Genesis 2:4-2:19) · Daf Bekhorot 17

ויקח.

לְקָחוֹ בִּדְבָרִים נָאִים וּפִתָּהוּ לִכָּנֵס (בראשית רבה):

ויקח *AND HE TOOK — He took him with kind words and induced him to enter (Genesis Rabbah 16:5).*

לא טוב היות וגו'.

שֶׁלֹּא יֹאמְרוּ שְׁתֵּי רְשׁוּיוֹת הֵן, הַקָּבָ"ה יָחִיד בָּעֶלְיוֹנִים וְאֵין לוֹ זוּג,

וְזֶה יָחִיד בַּתַּחְתּוֹנִים וְאֵין לוֹ זוּג (בראשית רבה):

לא טוב היות וגו' *IT IS NOT GOOD etc. — I shall make an help meet for him in order that people may not say that there are two Deities, the Holy One, blessed be He, the only One among the celestial Beings without a mate, and this one (Adam), the only one among the terrestrial beings, without a mate (Pirkei D'Rabbi Eliezer 12).*

עזר כנגדו.

זָכָה עֵזֶר; לֹא זָכָה כְּנֶגְדּוֹ לְהִלָּחֵם:

עזר כנגדו *A HELP MEET FOR HIM — (כנגדו literally, opposite, opposed to him) If he is worthy she shall be a help to him;*

if he is unworthy she shall be opposed to him, to fight him (Yevamot 63a).

וייצר מן האדמה.

הֵיא יְצִירָה הִיא עֲשִׂיָּה הָאֲמוּרָה לְמַעְלָה וַיַּעַשׂ אֱלֹקִים אֶת חַיַּת הָאָרֶץ וְגוֹ',

אֶלָּא בָּא וּפֵרֵשׁ שֶׁהָעוֹפוֹת נִבְרְאוּ מִן הָרָקָק,

ויצר מן האדמה *NOW OUT OF THE GROUND THE ETERNAL GOD HAD FORMED — The formation spoken of here is the creation mentioned above (1:25) "And God made the beast of the earth etc." and this statement comes (is repeated) here to point out that the fowls were created from the swamps;*

לְפִי שֶׁאָמַר לְמַעְלָה מִן הַמַּיִם נִבְרְאוּ וְכָאן אָמַר מִן הָאָרֶץ נִבְרְאוּ (חולין כ"ז),

for above it is said that they were created from the waters and here it states that they were created from the earth.

וְעוֹד לִמֶּדְךָ כָּאן שֶׁבְּשָׁעַת יְצִירָתָן מִיָּד בּוֹ בַּיּוֹם הֱבִיאָם אֶל הָאָדָם לִקְרוֹת לָהֶם שֵׁם.

וּבְדִבְרֵי אַגָּדָה יְצִירָה זוֹ לְשׁוֹן רְדוּי וְכִבּוּשׁ, כְּמוֹ כִּי תָצוּר אֶל עִיר (דברים כ"ד),

Furthermore it teaches you here that when they were created, immediately — on the very same day — He brought them to Adam to give them names (Chullin 27b);

שֶׁכְּבָשָׁן תַּחַת יָדוֹ שֶׁל אָדָם (בראשית רבה):

and in the statement of the Agada (Genesis Rabbah 17:4) we are told that this expression יצירה *means domination and subjugation, like (Deuteronomy 20:19)* כי תצור אל עיר *"when thou shalt besiege a city", for He subjugated them under the power of Adam.*

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr

DAILY READER

PARSHAT BERESHIT

Firstborns, changed things, and the breath of life

Monday, 5 October 2026 · Aliyah 2/7 (Genesis 2:4-2:19) · Daf Bekhorot 17

וכל אשר יקרא לו האדם נפש חיה וגו'.

סָרְסֵהוּ וּפָרְשֵׁהוּ, כֹּל נֶפֶשׁ חַיָּה אֲשֶׁר יִקְרָא לוֹ הָאָדָם שֵׁם, הוּא שְׁמוֹ לְעוֹלָם:

וכל אשר יקרא לו האדם נפש חיה וגו — *Invert it (the phrases of the sentence) and then explain it thus:*

every living creature to which Adam should give a name — that should remain its name forever.

HOW RASHI USES HIS SOURCES

Midrash, compressed into peshat

On וייצר (2:7) Rashi writes: 'נכתב ביצירתה שני יודי, יצירה לעולם הזה ויצירה לתחיית המתים, שתי יצירות' — two formations, for this world and for resurrection; but 'אבל בבהמה שאינה עומדת לדין לא י"ן' — for animals, which face no judgment, the double yod was not written. The reading is lifted nearly verbatim from the Bereshit Rabbah 14:5 material named in his linked sources; Rashi's only addition is the contrast with animals, turning an aggadic observation into a theological distinction.

On עפר מן האדמה (2:7) the method is compression without attribution: 'מכל האדמה מארבע רוחות שכל מקום שימות שם תהא קולטתו לקבורה, צבר עפרו' — He gathered man's dust from the whole earth, from its four corners, so that wherever he dies the earth will receive him for burial — then א"ד, a second tradition: the dust was taken from the future site of the altar ('תעשה לי מזבח אדמה'), hoping it will atone for him. Two aggadot from Sanhedrin 38a and the midrashim are fused into one gloss, no 'our rabbis said' in sight. That is Rashi's signature: the sources disappear into the peshat.

WORD STUDIES

Four words from the aliyah

Four words from the aliyah — two divine names, the ground itself, and its Aramaic shadow — each carrying the Garden's theology in miniature. The אלקים narrative draws on a full Maagarim citation sweep (18,278 attestations); the ארעא narrative on the Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon. Fresh Maagarim sweeps for יהוה and אדמה were blocked today, so those two are grounded in the aliyah's Hebrew, Onkelos, and Rashi.

אֱלֹקִים

Jastrow · אלקים

— , v. אלוה

Klein · אלקים

m.n. pl.

— God (pl. of majesty).

BDB · אלקים

— n.m.pl. (f. 1 K 11:33; on number of occurrences of אל, אלוה, אלקים cf. also Nesl.c.)

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr

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Maagarim

אלקים — 18278 attestations, root אלה 1 (אל).

אלקים opens the aliyah already paired: ביום עשות יהוה אלקים (2:4) — the double name that marks the second creation story, where Genesis 1 knew only אלקים. Rashi, on ה' אלקים at 2:5, reads the pair as name-plus-title: 'ה' הוא שמו, אלקים שהוא שליט ושופט על כל' — the Tetragrammaton is His name; אלקים says what He is, ruler and judge over all. Maagarim's 775 pages of citations tell the longer journey: the word starts in Genesis 1's creation fiat, runs through every genre of Hebrew for three millennia, and lands in 1930s belles-lettres — Bialik, and Shami's 1937 ומעה אלאהבל'ג, where a village sheikh is still ידיד אלקים, "God's friend." From cosmic architect to village honorific: the word traveled from heaven to the street and never lost its weight. What the arc reveals: in the Garden the word grows a first name — God is not only the power that made things but the person with whom man will argue.

יְהוָֹה

Klein · יהוה

m.n.

— the proper name of God in the Bible, Tetragrammaton.

BDB · יהוה

— 6823 i.e. יהוה n.pr.dei Yahweh, the proper name of the God of Israel—(1. MT יהוה6518 (Qr אדני), or יהוה305 (Qr אלקים), in the combinations אדני יהוה & יהוה אדני (vid. אדני), and with prep. ביהוה, ל

BDB · יהוה[2]

— n.pr.dei, v. sub הוה p. 217 ff.

יהוה is the name God gives when He enters covenant — the verb "to be" (היה) folded into a proper noun, the God who shows up. Genesis 2 is its debut as a compound: יהוה אלקים, twenty times across chapters 2–3, then never again in Tanakh. The rest of Scripture chooses one name or the other; only Eden gets both at once. By the Second Temple period the Name was no longer pronounced — readers substitute אדני, and our printed יהוה wears the vowels of אדני, a medieval typesetter's compromise fossilized on the page. Rashi's gloss says it plainly: ה' הוא שמו — this is His name, while אלקים is His title. The journey: from the unspoken Name too holy for the lips, to the intimate half of the Garden's double name — the God who forms man with His hands and walks in the garden לרוח היום. What the arc reveals: Eden is the one place where transcendence and intimacy share a single breath.

אֲדָמָה

Klein · אדמה

noun, feminine; root אדם

— ground, earth, soil; land, country

BDB · אדמה

n.f.

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr

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— ground, land — esp. as tilled; the earth as arable soil, opp. ארץ as territory

אדמה — the ground — is the aliyah's hinge word. Man is עפר מן האדמה, dust from the ground (2:7); the animals too are formed מן האדמה (2:19), and every tree is grown "מן האדמה" (2:9). Everything in the Garden is ground-born. It sits in a family of red words: אדם (man), דם (blood), אדם (red) — the human named for his raw material, red earth that bleeds. Rashi hears the echo and gathers the aggadah on עפר מן האדמה: God collected man's dust 'רוחות מכל האדמה מארבע' — from the whole earth, from its four corners — so that wherever man dies, the ground will take him back. The journey: the word starts as a recipe (dust plus breath equals a living soul) and ends as a destiny — from the ground you came, to the ground you return. In this aliyah, אדמה is both cradle and grave.

אַרְעָא

Jastrow · ארעא

f.

— (רע, h. q. v.) [the brittle] land, earth, ground, field. Targ. Gen. I, 1. Targ. Y. Gen. XVI, 5; a. fr.—B. Bath. 29ᵃ חדא א׳ one field; v. באגא.—Bekh. 25ᵇ דחשוכא א׳ a land of darkness (Babylon); a. fr.—Sabb. 65ᵃ בת א׳

Jastrow · ארעא

m.

— (ארע I) accident, occurrence. Targ. Ruth II, 3.—[*Pl. ארעייא evils, diseases. Targ. Y. Deut. XXVIII, 60 (prob. to be read מרעיא).]

Klein · ארעא

f.n.

ארעא never appears in the Hebrew column — it lives in the Aramaic one. Where the verse says ארץ ('אלה תולדות השמים והארץ', 2:4), Onkelos writes ארעא: 'אילין תולדת שמיא וארעא'. The CAL entry (ʾrʿ, ʾrʿʾ, Common Aramaic, feminine) spreads across six senses: the soil you stand on, the country you live in, the Earth beneath Heaven — even "floor" in Palmyrene inscriptions and "residue" in Syriac alchemy. Cognate with Hebrew ארץ, but with the telltale consonant shift: Aramaic ע where Hebrew has צ (ʾrʕ vs ʾrṣ), one of the classic fingerprints of the language. The same root renders אדמה too: עפר מן האדמה becomes עפרא מן אדמתא (2:7) — and here the translation costs something, because in Aramaic ארעא sounds nothing like אדם, so the Hebrew pun dies in transit. Onkelos uses one word-family for both the cosmic earth and the local ground. What the arc reveals: the Targum flattens a Hebrew distinction the verse keeps — and in doing so tells us how its audience heard the Garden: not geology, but homeland.

y Jev (jev-1.13.0). Mikra: Sefaria Hebrew + Targum Onkelos. Rashi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Pr